

MINUTES OF MEETING HELD November 3rd, 2025 OF GRADUATE AND PROFESSIONAL STUDENT COUNCIL, EXECUTIVE BOARD

A meeting of the Graduate and Professional Student Council (GPSC), Executive Board (EB) was convened on Monday, November 3rd at 5:00 PM held at GPSC house and on zoom.

1. Call to Order

Time meeting begins: 5:00 pm

Roll call: Mourad Abdennebi, Naama Levy, Travis Dean, Mehrdad Aghayari, Milad Hasankhani, Rishabh Bhattad, Roselyn Amamoo, Solange Quintana, Elham Chalebi

2. Call to Audience

The EB may not discuss items that are not on the agenda. Therefore, action taken as a result of public comment will be limited to directing staff to study the matter or scheduling the matter for consideration at a later date.

3. Review and Approve Meeting Minutes

The minutes from the previous meeting (October 17th, 2025) were reviewed and approved.

4. Officer Reports

- President:

- Thanked the board for the successful Halloween event.
- Expressed condolences for the three undergraduate students who passed away in the recent hit-and-run accident. Noted he was in touch with ASUA and Student Affairs, who are supporting the families.
- Reported progress on securing a dedicated graduate student lounge on the 3rd or 4th floor of the Student Union, expected to be available after remodeling (potentially next year).
- Provided an update on the "Nicer Gratitude Dinner" (Thanksgiving event):
 - The event is a collaboration with ASUA and Student Affairs.
 - It is confirmed for **Tuesday, November 25th, from 6:00 PM to 9:00 PM** in the Bear Down Building.
 - The event will be buffet-style with music and games.
 - The cost is covered by external funders (Grad College, ISS, etc.); GPSC will contribute \$0.
 - An RSVP will be needed to plan for the \$15/person catering cost.

- Executive Vice President:

- Sent a follow-up email to the UA Foundation President and his assistant to



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- gain access to the GPSC donation foundation account. Awaiting a response; no major operational updates.
- **Administrative Vice President:**
 - Announced personal news that this will be her last semester as she has decided to leave her PhD program. She expressed relief in her decision and recommended the board recruit her replacement from the current General Council for a smoother transition.
 - The Professional Development committee has been officially renamed the **Student Advocacy Committee**.
 - The committee is focusing on three key areas: 1) Developing a formal grievance process for students, 2) Advocating for year-long tech rentals from the library, and 3) Securing dedicated graduate student space.
 - **Treasurer:**
 - No major updates. Noted that funding for the Cap & Gown program would be discussed later in the meeting.
 - **Secretary:**
 - Sent the formal proposal for the "GPSC Chatbot" to the board for review.
 - Noted that the technology (audio, visuals) in the new GC meeting room in the residential housing building was not good, causing issues for attendees.
 - **Assembly Chair:**
 - Agreed with the Secretary's report on tech issues in the new GC room, despite prior testing. He suggested trying the venue one more time with more setup, but if it fails, the council should vote to return to Zoom-only meetings.
 - Expressed concern that the last GC meeting agenda was changed mid-meeting. He recommended that the long-term goals (stipends, healthcare, etc.) be kept on "Old Business" at every meeting to provide consistent, brief updates rather than re-voting.
 - **Director of Communications:**
 - Released three newsletters and promoted various events (career series, faculty jobs, etc.).
 - Planned and decorated for the successful Halloween social.
 - Working on the Cap & Gown rental program and a new survey for the Rec Center.
 - Instagram followers have increased by approximately more than 300 since the semester began.
 - **Director of Grants & Funding:**
 - The review for PPG and Travel grants is complete, and the committee met to decide cutoffs. Awaiting the Graduate College's eligibility check before sending award notifications.
 - The BNM Grant will open on Tuesday, November 11th.



- Assisting the new admin (Katie) by finding reviewers for the ReaP grants.
- **Director of Policy:**
 - Preparing for the ABOR meeting on Nov. 23rd; creating an info form for interested reps.
 - Scheduling an advocacy training session for January.
 - Working on launching four surveys: GA Stipend, Academic Freedom, Financial Stress, and Health Insurance.
 - Monitoring the potential federal government shutdown and its impact on international students.
 - The International Student Fund proposal is finalized, and she is scheduling a meeting with volunteers to plan next steps.

5. New Business & Action Items

- **GPSC and International Student Services (ISS) Open Forum:** President reported that ISS had responded to GPSC's call to action regarding compact and international student issues. ISS proposed a collaborative "Open Forum" for students to informally ask questions about visas, status, etc., with ISS staff present. A debate ensued over whether GPSC should "collaborate" (co-host) or simply "promote" the event. The consensus was that GPSC lacks the legal expertise to co-host and should instead promote the event as an official ISS response, thereby maintaining a clear distinction of roles. A motion was made and seconded by Travis to hold an email vote for the GC to approve this "promotion-only" strategy.
- **GPSC Representative Stipend Restructure:** President explained that international students could have potential issues with "GPSC stipends" due to visa work-hour restrictions even though the position itself is voluntary and the stipends are not considered wages. The Graduate College (via Rachel) proposed a solution: GPSC must draft a proposal to rename the stipend to "**Professional Development Awards**." This would classify the payment as an award (like a grant), making it permissible for international students. A motion was made and seconded by Rishabh to approve this name change and move forward with the proposal. The motion **passed unanimously**. The Treasurer and Grants Director will work on the draft.
- **GPSC and Office of Public Safety Meeting Agenda:** The board discussed the agenda for the upcoming meeting with the Office of Public Safety on November 10th. Key topics identified include:
 - The rise in e-bike and bicycle thefts.
 - Transparency and concerns about the new Flock security cameras.
 - Presence of ICE/Border Patrol on campus.
 - Poor lighting in many areas of campus and at crosswalks, citing the



recent student deaths as a critical safety concern.

- **Rec Center Sports/Wellness Programming:** President Abdennebi reported that Troy (Rec Center Director) is open to offering free, graduate-student-only wellness classes (e.g., yoga, mindfulness). A discussion was held on whether to survey students for new class ideas or request free access to existing classes. The board decided to create a survey that includes both existing and new options, but to coordinate its release to avoid survey fatigue with other pending surveys.

- **Items Requiring Vote/Decision:**

- **Student Showcase Committee Plan:** The board revisited the Student Showcase. President Abdennebi confirmed with the Office of Research that the \$15,000 in funding is earmarked specifically for showcase awards and cannot be reallocated to grants. He noted that additional funding for the event itself (~\$15,000) would be fundraised from the Grad College (\$5k pledged), Provost's Office, and external sponsors. A motion was made to approve moving forward with the Student Showcase. The motion **passed** by majority with 3 votes in favor (1 abstain). An email vote will be sent to the General Council for final approval.
- **GPSC Chatbot Proposal:** Secretary presented his proposal for a "GPSC Chatbot" (cost approx. \$500-\$1,500/year) that would be trained on all GPSC documents. This would serve as a "digital historian" to help with summer transitions and answer questions. The plan is to pilot the tool with the EB first. A motion was made to approve the pilot program. The motion **passed** by majority with 3 votes in favor (1 Abstain).
- **Summer Transition & Election Timeline:** AVP led a discussion on her formal proposal to improve the officer transition, which was a significant challenge this year. The board discussed needing a formal, Grad College-led orientation. A major discussion point was raised by EVP about changing the bylaws to make the Secretary, Treasurer, and Assembly Chair positions part of the general student body election, rather than internal GC appointments, to improve transparency and alignment. This was countered by concerns that it might disqualify international students and prevent experienced GC members from stepping up. The complex discussion was tabled for a future meeting to gather more information.
- **GC Guest Speaker Planning:** The board reviewed a list of potential guest speakers for future GC meetings, including David E. (AI), Cassandra J. (Wellness), Ruth (DRC), Filipe G. (ABOR), and John Arnold (CFO, Stipends). The board decided to prioritize inviting **John Arnold** and **Cassandra J.** to upcoming meetings.

6. Motion to Adjourn

- Motion to adjourn the meeting by President:
 - The motion was seconded by Travis.



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- The meeting was adjourned at 6:50 pm.

Dated this 3rd day of November 2025

Graduate and Professional Student Council Executive Board

Rishabh Bhattad, Secretary